
15th Sunday in Ordinary Time (Year A)

12 July 2026

The Soil of Our Lives

This Sunday Jesus tells us the parable of the sower. It is one of the most familiar stories in the Gospels. A farmer scatters seed. Some falls on the path, some on rocky ground, some among thorns, and some on rich soil. Only the rich soil produces a harvest.

Anyone who has ever grown anything in soil knows that you can have the best seed in the world, but if the ground isn't ready, nothing will come of it. The work is in the preparation. The digging, the clearing, the weeding. It is slow and unspectacular, and nobody sees it. But it makes all the difference.

Isaiah reminds us this weekend that God's Word never returns to Him empty. Like the rain and the snow that water the earth, His word always accomplishes what it was sent to do. The seed is never the problem. God is endlessly generous. He scatters His grace everywhere, on all of us, without measure and without favourites. The question the parable puts to each of us is a simple one: what kind of ground is He landing on?

Every one of us has been planted with gifts. Gifts of faith, of kindness, of patience, of prayer. Some of them are lying dormant because the soil of our lives has become hardened, or crowded, or shallow. The worries of the week, the busyness, the old hurts we haven't let go of — these are the thorns and the stones. They don't destroy the seed. They just stop it growing.

The good news is that soil can always be worked: A little time in prayer each day. An honest look at what is choking the Word in us. A return to the Sacraments. Small, quiet acts of clearing the ground! When we do that, our roots go down deeper into God, and we find a steadiness that the heat of life cannot wither.

St Paul tells us the whole of creation is groaning, waiting to be set free. That freedom begins in small plots of ground, that is in hearts like yours and mine that let the Word take root and grow.

So this week, ask the Lord: what needs clearing in me? Then let Him in with the spade! The harvest He promises is thirty, sixty, a hundredfold.

Fr Sean

FATIMA PILGRIMAGE

I'm in Fatima with Fr Stephen Baxter (our newly ordained) and 60 others from our Parishes and others in Fatima. Please be assured of our prayers at all our Masses, Rosaries and Processions for you all and your intentions, and I ask for yours for us as well. Thanks to Fr Michael Canny PP, Fr Patrick Lagan CC and Fr Joshy Parokkaran CC from Waterside for providing cover while I'm away.

We welcome into God's Family through the Sacrament of Baptism:

Lottie Kimberley Jowett

Remy Petroosbabakhan

May they Rest in Peace

Deaths

Gerard O'Connell, 60 Belldoo

Bernard O'Brien, 2 Mourne Park

Jackie Begley, 217 Ballycolman Estate

Jim Harley, 1 Melmount Park

Thomas Martin Roulston, 89 Carlton Drive

Anniversaries

Sr. Monica O'Kane, Mary Kate Mullen, William Robinson

Conor McCarron, Tony McAleer, Susan Logue

Vincent Gormley, Betty McColgan, Ellen Jane McCormick

John Ellis, Frances O'Connor, Tommy McGarrigle

Gerard Blake, Joe Millar, Tom Skehan

Kay McGuigan, William Devine, Jude Crotty

Frank Molloy, Maureen Devine, Eunan Herron

Tommy Finlay, Harry McCrossan, Anne McCay

Magdalene Curry, Molly McDaid, David Coyle

Deirdre Drumm Pearce, Dessie Drumm, Grace Drumm

Noel Brennan, Joe McNulty, Alice Alexander

Robert Brennan, George Fitzpatrick, Francis Moss

Margaret Quigley, Packie Duncan, Frank McElwee

Michael McDaid, Ann McShane, Patrick Early

George Early, Sarah Early, George Devenney

David McDaid, Marie Henderson

Announcements

Last week's collections amounted to: **Melmount:** £3373.00; **Sion Mills:** £1465.00. Thank you. Those who pay to the weekly collection or any special collections, including Priest's Collection by cheque are asked that all cheques should be made payable to 'Melmount Parish' or 'Sion Mills Parish' depending on the Parish. This is a banking requirement. *Parishioners can still leave their contributions in the Parish Office. If the Office is closed, please use the letterbox.*

Parish Bulletin This is the last bulletin until September.

Exposition of the Blessed Sacrament will take place in St. Mary's, Melmount tomorrow, Monday 13 July after 10.00am Mass until 6.30pm.

Vocations We pray for the men called to serve the Church as priests of our diocese, that their hearts will be the fertile soil Jesus needs to receive the seed which is His Word, and that they will spread His Word, His Good News, by their preaching and by the example of their lives.

Adoration Everyday The Blessed Sacrament can be adored in the Adoration Room, St. Theresa's, Sion Mills anytime while the church is open.

Baptism Dates Melmount

July: Sunday 19; Saturday 25; Sunday 26.

August: Saturday 8; Saturday 29.

September: Saturday 5; Sunday 13; Saturday 19.

October: Sunday 4; Saturday 10; Saturday 17; Saturday 24.

November: Sunday 8; Saturday 14; Saturday 21; Saturday 28.

Baptisms will be at 3.30pm on a Saturday and 12.45pm on a Sunday.

To book a Baptism contact the Parish Office on 71383777 during office hours.

Accord Marriage Preparation Courses (Pre-Marriage Courses) will take place in September 25/26 and November 20/21. All courses are now online for booking at www.accordni.com

Please Note: These courses are in person and not online courses.

Accord Derry will NOT be facilitating courses during October or December.

Safeguarding Notice If you have any concerns with regard to the Safeguarding of children within the church please contact Marie O'Kane, the Diocesan Designated Liaison Person (DLP) on +447596500793 or email@ dlp@derrydiocese.org. *Northern Ireland emergency services:* PSNI on 101; *Social Services:* Gateway Services, Western HSC Trust, 028 71314090 and ask for the Duty Social Worker. *Regional Emergency Social Work Services* 0800 1979 995.

The Parish Draws for July and August took place on Wednesday 8 July. The winners are as follows:

July Draw

£500: 1027 Genevieve O'Neill – *Genevieve O'Neill*
£250: 1350 Concepta McGarrigle – *Ann Donaghey*
£250: 1708 Thomas Moore – *Teresa Quigg*
£250: 1338 Marianne Patton – *Carol-ann Stewart*
£150: 1995 Tammy McNulty – *Irene Callan*
£150: 1304 Ina O'Neill – *Sheelagh McKelvey*
£150: 1719 Christine McHugh – *Teresa Quigg*
£100: 1243 Bronagh Lynch – *Declan Duffy*
£100: 1669 Declan McColgan – *Madeleine McColgan*
£100: 1702 Terrie Logue - *Genevieve O'Neill*

August Draw

£500: 1756 Vincent McCarron – *Katrina Houston*
£250: 1626 Anne Neeson – *Madeleine McColgan*
£250: 1379 Gary McNicholl – *Sheelagh McKelvey*
£250: 1862 Emma Lynch – *Elizabeth O'Hare*
£150: 1825 Susan McGuinness – *John Donohoe*
£150: 1684 Teresa Boggs – *Katrina Houston*
£150: 1380 Bridget McCrory – *Sheelagh McKelvey*
£100: 1010 Mya McNulty – *Dolores Houston*
£100: 1258 Corrine Hannigan – *Elizabeth O'Hare*
£100: 1507 Jacintha Gillespie - *Elizabeth O'Hare*



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